

ASIAN WILDLIFE

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ASIA STRETCHES FROM the frozen Arctic in the north to the warm tropics in the south. Although much of Asia is undulating plain, it also boasts the awesome mountain range of the Himalayas. Much of the interior receives little rain, but parts of India hold the world record for annual rainfall. This continent of contrasts provides many habitats, each with its own characteristic plants and animals. Many of the world's best known endangered species, such as giant pandas and tigers, live in Asia. But many less publicized, smaller animals and plants are also threatened by the steady spread of human populations.

Temperate forest wildlife

Asian temperate woodlands are rich in species of broadleaved trees. Summers are mild, but winters can be cold, and after the leaves have fallen, there is little food or shelter. Some animals migrate or hibernate; others, such as the Japanese macaque, are adapted to the cold.



Monkey eating snow

Thick, shaggy coat

Japanese macaque

Living throughout most of Japan, the Japanese macaque lives in a more northerly climate than any other monkey. In winter it grows a thick coat for protection, and some troops sit in hot springs to avoid the chill of a snowstorm. Roots, buds, and shoots form its winter diet.

Japanese emperor butterfly

Only the male Japanese emperor has an iridescent purple sheen, but both sexes have spotted wings. This pattern breaks up their outline, making it difficult to see where they land on sun-flecked foliage. Their caterpillars are leaf green, to camouflage them on the leaves of celtis trees, on which they feed.



Purple iridescence of male

White spots

Rainforest wildlife

Asia's rainforests are warm all year round, but they do have short dry seasons. They are festooned with lianas and epiphytes. The rainforest provides homes for animals at all levels, from fruit bats in the canopy to tigers on the forest floor.



Long aerial roots

Banyan tree

Some fig trees, such as the banyan tree, start life as a tiny seedling that grows in the crown of another rainforest tree. The banyan tree sends aerial roots down to the ground, that enmesh and kill the host tree.



Striped coat provides camouflage in forest.

Tiger

The tiger spends much of its day roaming through its rainforest territory, stalking prey. Tigers love water, and to avoid the heat of the day, they cool down by basking in shallow pools.

Bill is used to kill snakes and scorpions.



Saltwater crocodile

Large reptiles, such as saltwater crocodiles, lie out on the shores of rainforest rivers in the morning sun to warm up their bodies. Later on, when the Sun gets too hot, the crocodiles return to the water to cool down.

Rhinoceros hornbill

With its loud call and noisy wingbeats, the rhinoceros hornbill is a very noticeable rainforest inhabitant. It uses its huge bill with great dexterity to pick fruit and kill prey.

The papery orange lanterns enclose berries.



Grassland wildlife

Asia has both tropical savannahs and vast plains of temperate steppes, with hot, dry summers. However, grasses and drought-resistant shrubs do grow there. Large animals have adapted to conserve moisture; smaller ones shelter in burrows.



Heavy snout

Saiga antelope

Herd of saiga antelopes migrate south in winter to escape severe weather. They return north in summer, when the grasses are more plentiful. Saigas have a mucous-lined sac in the snout that warms inhaled air in winter and filters out dust in the hot, dry summer.



Tawny eagle

The tawny eagle nests in shrubs and trees by watercourses. It flies long distances over steppes and semi-arid deserts in search of food. The tawny eagle is a skillful hunter, but it increases its chances of getting enough food by feeding on carrion and stealing other predators' prey.

Hooked beak for tearing flesh of prey

Eagle has pushed off ground to launch itself into the air.